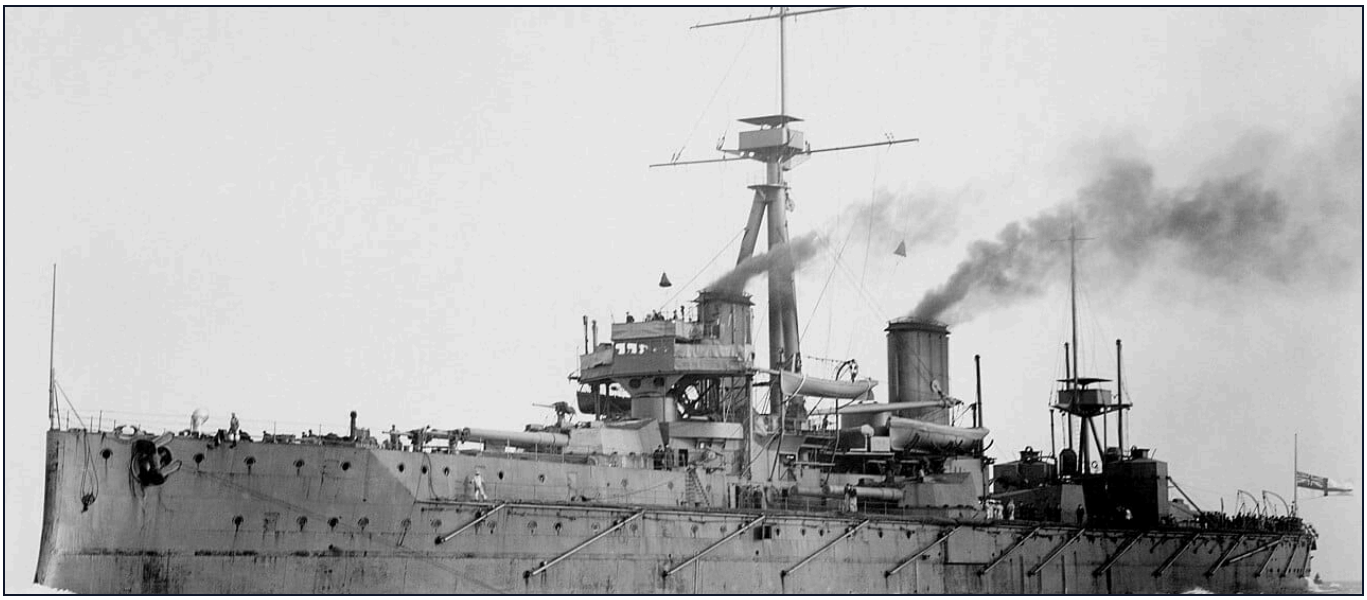
1871 – 1914

CAUSES OF THE GREAT WAR

Imperial Ambition, Naval Rivalry & The Collapse of Peace



Primary Photograph (c. 1906–1907): HMS Dreadnought at sea, the all-big-gun battleship that sparked the Anglo-German naval arms race.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY • UNIT NARRATIVE SYNOPSIS 1871 – 1914

"Decades of imperial vanity, secret alliances, and dreadnought arms races wound the clockwork of European catastrophe. When a teenage assassin fired two fatal shots on the streets of Sarajevo in June 1914, thirty days of diplomatic brinkmanship sleepwalked an entire continent into ruin. Trace the geopolitical friction of European empires, the naval race, and the fatal railway timetables that sparked world war."

THE CANONICAL ENQUIRIES • SCHEME OF LEARNING DIRECTORY **A3 SADDLE-STITCH FORMAT**

Enquiry 01	**German Unification & Bismarck**	*How did 1871 rupture European peace?*	**Page 3**
Enquiry 02	**Imperial Rivalry & Morocco**	*Did Weltpolitik push powers to brink of war?*	**Page 4**
Enquiry 03	**Naval Arms Race & Dreadnought**	*Why did battleships reset naval supremacy?*	**Page 5**
Enquiry 04	**Alliance Systems & The Balkans**	*Did alliances protect or doom peace?*	**Page 6**
Enquiry 05	**The July Crisis & Sarajevo**	*Why did two shots ignite thirty-seven days of madness?*	**Page 7**

CORE CONCEPTS Realpolitik • Balance of Power • Alsace-Lorraine • Weltpolitik • Moroccan Crises • Dreadnought Race • Triple Entente • Balkan Powder Keg • Sarajevo • Blank Cheque • Schlieffen Plan

CHRONOLOGICAL TURNING POINTS

Twelve Decisive Milestones & Causal Dominoes Culminating in the Outbreak of War

1862–1871

Bismarck's Wars & The Unification of Germany

Ref [1.1–1.2]

Through "blood and iron" wars against Denmark, Austria, and France, Prussia unifies Germany and fundamentally ruptures the European balance of power.

18 Jan 1871

Proclamation of the German Empire at Versailles

Ref [1.2–1.3]

King Wilhelm I is crowned Kaiser in the Hall of Mirrors. Defeated France cedes Alsace-Lorraine and pays 5 billion gold francs in indemnity.

May 1871

Annexation of Alsace-Lorraine & The Cult of Revanche

Ref [1.3–1.4]

Seizure of border fortresses Metz and Strasbourg alienates 1.6 million French citizens, creating an implacable enemy and four decades of French hatred.

1871–1890

Bismarckian Isolation & The Secret Reinsurance Treaty

Ref [1.5–1.6]

Haunted by fear of a two-front encirclement, Chancellor Bismarck spins a defensive diplomatic web, culminating in the 1887 Russian treaty.

1884–1885

The Berlin Conference & The Scramble for Africa

Ref [2.1–2.2]

Fourteen powers partition Africa under "effective occupation". Latecomer Germany receives only scattered territories, sparking imperial resentment.

1890

Dismissal of Bismarck & Wilhelm II's Weltpolitik

Ref [2.3]

Kaiser Wilhelm II fires Bismarck, lets the Russian treaty lapse, and adopts Weltpolitik, demanding Germany's aggressive "place in the sun".

1898–1900

Admiral von Tirpitz & The German Navy Laws

Ref [3.1–3.2]

Germany legislates massive battle fleet construction, deploying the "Risk Theory" to threaten the Royal Navy in the North Sea.

1904–1907

The Diplomatic Revolution: The Triple Entente

Ref [4.1–4.3]

Alarmed by German naval expansion, Britain abandons "Splendid Isolation" to sign defensive ententes with France (1904) and Russia (1907).

1905–1906

The First Moroccan Crisis: Kaiser at Tangier

Ref [2.4]

Wilhelm II visits Tangier to challenge French control. The 1906 Algeciras Conference isolates Germany and cements the Anglo-French Entente.

Feb 1906

Launch of HMS Dreadnought & Naval Arms Race

Ref [3.3–3.5]

Royal Navy launches the first all-big-gun, steam-turbine battleship, making all older fleets obsolete and resetting naval competition.

1908–1911

Bosnian Annexation Crisis & The Panther at Agadir

Ref [2.5, 4.4]

Austria annexes Bosnia, humiliating Serbia and Russia. In 1911, German gunboat SMS Panther arrives in Agadir, bringing Europe close to war.

28 Jun – 4 Aug 1914

Sarajevo Assassination, July Crisis & Outbreak of War

Ref [5.1–5.5]

Gavrilo Princip assassinates Archduke Franz Ferdinand. The German Blank Cheque, Austrian ultimatum, and railway mobilization trigger general war.

ENQUIRY 01

PILLAR 1 • CORE NARRATIVE

German Unification, Franco-Prussian War & Bismarck (1871–1890)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION How did the creation of the German Empire and the seizure of Alsace-Lorraine permanently rupture European peace?

[1.1] THE FRAGMENTED CHESSBOARD, ZOLLVEREIN & PRUSSIAN POWER (1862–1866)

Before 1871, Central Europe was deeply divided. In 1815, the Congress of Vienna organized the region into **thirty-nine independent states (39 independent states)**. Two rival powers competed for control. Catholic Austria ruled a vast, multinational empire. In contrast, Protestant **Prussia** was a disciplined military powerhouse, rich in coal, railways, and Krupp steel.

In 1834, Prussia launched the **Zollverein** (Customs Union). This agreement removed internal taxes between German states while deliberately locking out Austria. German trade boomed on Prussian railways. In 1862, **Otto von Bismarck** became Prussian Minister-President. Bismarck bypassed parliament and declared his ruthless philosophy: *"The great questions of the day will not be decided by speeches and majority votes... but by iron and blood."* Practicing pure *Realpolitik*, Bismarck led Prussia to swift military victories over Denmark in 1864 and Austria in 1866.

[1.2] THE SEDAN DEBACLE & PROCLAMATION AT VERSAILLES (1870–1871)

To unite the southern German states with Prussia, Bismarck needed a common enemy. In July 1870, he edited the famous **Ems Telegram** to make it look like King Wilhelm I had insulted the French ambassador. Furious, Emperor Napoleon III declared war. France was completely unprepared. Prussian railways and heavy Krupp artillery crushed French defenses. On 1 September 1870, German forces encircled the French army at the **Battle of Sedan**, capturing Napoleon III and 104,000 soldiers.

The French government refused to surrender, triggering the brutal **Siege of Paris**. Starving citizens survived by eating horses and zoo animals. On **18 January 1871**, Bismarck delivered the ultimate humiliation. Inside the famous **Hall of Mirrors at the Palace of Versailles**, German princes proclaimed King Wilhelm I the first German Emperor (Kaiser). The German Empire was forged through war.

[1.3] THE TREATY OF FRANKFURT & ANNEXATION OF ALSACE-LORRAINE (MAY 1871)

In May 1871, the two nations signed the **Treaty of Frankfurt**. German leaders designed the treaty to crush French military power. France had to pay a massive fine of **five billion gold francs (5 billion gold francs)**. German occupation troops remained on French soil until every centime was paid. Even worse was the territorial loss: Germany seized the border provinces of **Alsace** and **Lorraine**.

This annexation tore away 1.6 million French citizens and vital iron-ore basins. The ancient fortress city of Metz and the cathedral city of Strasbourg became fortified German strongholds. Overnight, forty-one million people and the Krupp arms foundries merged into a giant military empire. A united Germany now stood at the heart of Europe.

[1.4] FRENCH REVANCHE & THE CULT OF THE LOST PROVINCES (1871–1889)

Losing Alsace-Lorraine deeply scarred the French nation for over forty years. In Paris, the statue of Strasbourg on the Place de la Concorde was draped in black mourning cloth. French schools taught generations of boys that their greatest duty was **Revanche** (revenge)—the recovery of their lost land.

In classrooms, wall maps showed Alsace-Lorraine shaded pitch-black as the *"tache noire"* (black spot). France introduced compulsory military training, and children practiced military marching in school drills. As French statesman Léon Gambetta declared: *"Think of it always; speak of it never."* No French politician could ever make peace with Berlin while German troops occupied Strasbourg and Metz.

[1.5] BISMARCKIAN ISOLATION, THE REINSURANCE TREATY & TWO-FRONT DREAD (1871–1890)

British statesman **Benjamin Disraeli** warned Parliament that German unification had destroyed the balance of power. Bismarck knew France would never forgive its defeat. For the next twenty years, Bismarck had one central goal: **keep France diplomatically isolated to protect German peace**.

Germany dreaded a **war on two fronts (encirclement)**, attacked by France from the west and Russia from the east. To prevent this, Bismarck built a network of defensive alliances. His masterpiece was the secret 1887 **Reinsurance Treaty** with Russia, promising neutrality if either empire faced war. Bismarck's diplomacy kept Europe peaceful. However, in 1888, the impetuous young **Kaiser Wilhelm II** took power. In 1890, Wilhelm fired Bismarck and let the Russian treaty lapse. Germany had stepped onto the path toward dangerous two-front encirclement.

ENQUIRY 02

PILLAR 1 • CORE NARRATIVE

Imperial Rivalry, the Scramble for Africa & the Moroccan Crises (1884–1911)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION How did imperial ambition in Africa and Kaiser Wilhelm II's "Weltpolitik" bring European powers to the brink of war?

[2.1] THE SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA & THE BERLIN CONFERENCE (1884–1885)

Between 1881 and 1914, European powers raced to conquer Africa in the **Scramble for Africa**. Factories in Europe demanded cheap raw materials—rubber, copper, cotton, and palm oil. Rulers also wanted new trade markets and imperial prestige. In 1870, Europeans controlled under ten percent of Africa; by 1914, they ruled ninety percent.

To avoid war among European powers, Bismarck organized the **Berlin Conference (1884–1885)**. Fourteen nations met to agree rules for carving up the continent. They agreed the rule of **effective occupation**: countries had to set up physical offices, soldiers, and administration before claiming land. European diplomats drew straight borders across maps, completely ignoring African languages, cultures, and historic tribal kingdoms.

[2.2] KAISER WILHELM II,"WELTPOLITIK" & "A PLACE IN THE SUN" (1890–1897)

Bismarck insisted Germany was a satisfied European power with no need for distant colonies. Pointing to a map, he declared: *"Here lies Russia, and here lies France, and we are in the middle; that is my map of Africa."* But in 1888, the young, ambitious **Kaiser Wilhelm II** took the German throne. Wilhelm wanted personal glory and dismissed Bismarck in 1890, an event dubbed "Dropping the Pilot."

The Kaiser demanded that Germany become a global superpower. In 1897, Bernhard von Bülow announced that Germany demanded its **"place in the sun" (Platz an der Sonne)**. This aggressive imperial policy was called **Weltpolitik** ("World Policy"). Because Britain and France already owned the richest territories, Wilhelm decided to build a mighty battlefleet, putting Germany on a direct collision course with Britain.

[2.3] THE FIRST MOROCCAN CRISIS & THE LANDING AT TANGIER (MARCH 1905)

In April 1904, alarmed by rising German power, Britain and France signed the **Entente Cordiale** ("Friendly Understanding"). This was a colonial pact rather than a military alliance. France accepted British control of Egypt, while Britain accepted French influence over the Sultanate of **Morocco**. German leaders feared this new friendship would surround them.

On 31 March 1905, Kaiser Wilhelm II triggered the **First Moroccan Crisis**. Arriving in the Moroccan port of **Tangier** on a white horse, Wilhelm announced his support for the Sultan's independence. He challenged French control and demanded equal German trading rights. The Kaiser gambled that France would back down and that Britain would not support Paris. His gamble failed completely.

[2.4] THE ALGECIRAS CONFERENCE & GERMAN DIPLOMATIC ISOLATION (1906)

To resolve the Moroccan standoff, Germany demanded an international conference, expecting global support. In January 1906, diplomats met at the **Algeciras Conference** in southern Spain. The meeting ended in complete humiliation for Germany.

Instead of splitting Britain and France, German pressure pushed them closer together. British Foreign Secretary Sir Edward Grey firmly backed France. Russia, Italy, Spain, and the United States all voted to give France control over Moroccan police and banking. Only Austria-Hungary voted alongside Germany. Kaiser Wilhelm II left Algeciras furious. He was now convinced that the Great Powers were conspiring to encircle Germany, a paranoid fear known as **Einkreisung** (encirclement).

[2.5] THE SECOND MOROCCAN CRISIS: THE PANTHER AT AGADIR & MANSION HOUSE (JULY 1911)

In spring 1911, Moroccan tribes rebelled against the Sultan in Fez. France sent troops to restore order. Accusing France of breaking the Algeciras agreement, Germany used **gunboat diplomacy**. On **1 July 1911**, Germany sent the gunboat **SMS Panther** to the Atlantic port of **Agadir**, trying to force France into handing over the French Congo.

The gunboat provoked outrage in London because Agadir lay near vital British shipping routes. On 21 July 1911, British Chancellor **David Lloyd George** gave his famous **Mansion House Speech**. He warned that Britain would fight rather than accept peace through national humiliation. Germany backed down and accepted a small piece of the Congo. The crisis backfired on Germany: Britain and France were pushed into secret joint military talks to defend against a German invasion.

ENQUIRY 03

PILLAR 1 • CORE NARRATIVE

The Anglo-German Naval Arms Race & HMS Dreadnought (1898–1914)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations and reset naval supremacy?

[3.1] THE TWO-POWER STANDARD & BRITISH MARITIME SURVIVAL (1889–1897)

For Great Britain, naval supremacy was essential for national survival. As an island nation, Britain could not feed its people without ocean imports. By 1900, Britain imported four-fifths of its wheat and meat on merchant ships. If enemy battleships cut these supply routes, Britain would starve within six weeks. The Royal Navy also defended a global empire of four hundred million subjects.

In the **Naval Defence Act of 1889**, Britain established the **Two-Power Standard**. This law required the Royal Navy to be as large as the world's next two biggest navies combined (then France and Russia). British leaders believed that unmatched sea power was the best way to prevent continental wars.

[3.2] ADMIRAL VON TIRPITZ, GERMAN NAVAL LAWS & "RISK THEORY" (1898–1900)

In 1897, Kaiser Wilhelm II appointed **Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz** to run the Imperial Navy. Tirpitz believed Germany could not become a world empire without a powerful battlefleet. In 1898 and 1900, Tirpitz passed the famous **German Naval Laws** through the Reichstag, funding dozens of battleships for the new **High Seas Fleet**.

Tirpitz justified this cost using his **Risk Theory (Risikotheorie)**. Britain's navy was scattered around the globe protecting colonies. Germany would instead concentrate its fleet across the North Sea in ports like Wilhelmshaven and Kiel. Tirpitz argued that Britain would not risk a battle because heavy losses would ruin its naval supremacy over rivals. Tirpitz expected Britain to give in to German colonial demands. It was a disastrous miscalculation.

[3.3] THE DREADNOUGHT REVOLUTION: ALL-BIG-GUN TECHNOLOGY (FEBRUARY 1906)

Britain met the German challenge under First Sea Lord **Admiral Sir John "Jackie" Fisher**. Fisher recognized that older warships with mixed gun sizes were outdated. Building in secret at Portsmouth Dockyard, Fisher launched **HMS Dreadnought** in February 1906.

Dreadnought transformed naval warfare. It was the world's first "all-big-gun" battleship, armed with ten 12-inch heavy guns that fired 850-pound shells over eight miles. Powered by modern steam turbines, it cruised at 21 knots, faster than any battleship afloat. However, *Dreadnought* created a serious problem for Britain. By making older ships obsolete, it erased Britain's big lead of fifty pre-dreadnoughts to Germany's twenty. The naval race was reset to zero: **Britain 1, Germany 0**. Germany could now build dreadnoughts of its own.

[3.4] THE 1909 NAVAL PANIC: "WE WANT EIGHT AND WE WON'T WAIT!" (1909)

Between 1906 and 1908, Germany accelerated naval building, constructing four dreadnoughts each year. In late 1908, British intelligence discovered German shipyards were secretly stockpiling steel to build even faster. In January 1909, public alarm erupted in the **1909 Naval Panic**.

Prime Minister H.H. Asquith and Chancellor David Lloyd George had hoped to spend money on social reforms like pensions. However, newspapers, the public, and politicians launched a fierce campaign demanding more warships: *"We want eight and we won't wait!"* The government yielded to public pressure. Parliament voted to build eight super-dreadnoughts in a single year, comfortably out-building Germany but placing massive tax burdens on both countries.

[3.5] THE HALDANE MISSION FAILURE & STRATEGIC REDEPLOYMENT (1912–1914)

By 1912, the crushing cost of the naval race led Britain to seek a truce. British War Secretary **Lord Haldane** traveled to Berlin to propose a "naval holiday." Haldane offered to slow down dreadnought construction if Germany restricted its fleet. However, the Kaiser insisted that **Britain must pledge strict neutrality in any future European war**.

Britain refused because this pledge would allow Germany to crush France. The mission collapsed. In response, First Lord of the Admiralty **Winston Churchill** reorganized British naval defense. Britain pulled its main battleships from the Mediterranean Sea and placed sixty percent of the Royal Navy in the North Sea. Under a new agreement, the French navy guarded the Mediterranean, while Britain guarded the French coast. Germany had lost the naval race, but the rivalry permanently wrecked relations between London and Berlin.

ENQUIRY 04
PILLAR 1 • CORE NARRATIVE

The Alliance Systems & the Balkan Powder Keg (1879–1913)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Did European military alliances protect continental peace or guarantee a domino-effect catastrophe?

[4.1] THE CENTRAL EUROPEAN BLOC: DUAL ALLIANCE & TRIPLE ALLIANCE (1879–1882)

In October 1879, Chancellor Otto von Bismarck acted to prevent a hostile coalition between France and Russia. He negotiated the **Dual Alliance** with Austria-Hungary. Both empires promised mutual military support if attacked by Russia, and neutrality if attacked by another power. In 1882, Italy joined after losing Tunisia to France, creating the **Triple Alliance**.

Bismarck designed the alliance to defend Central Europe and deter foreign attacks. However, it had a dangerous flaw. The treaty tied Germany's military power to the weak, multi-ethnic Austro-Hungarian Empire. Ruled by the aging Emperor Franz Joseph, Austria-Hungary was fracturing under intense nationalist unrest.

[4.2] THE COUNTER-ALLIANCE: FRANCO-RUSSIAN ALLIANCE & TRIPLE ENTENTE (1894–1907)

In 1890, Kaiser Wilhelm II allowed Germany's secret Reinsurance Treaty with Russia to lapse. Needing money to build the Trans-Siberian Railway, Russia turned to France. In 1894, the two nations signed the **Franco-Russian Military Alliance**, promising mutual defense against Germany. Bismarck's worst fear—a two-front encirclement—had come true.

Alarmed by German naval expansion, Britain abandoned its traditional "Splendid Isolation." Britain settled colonial disputes with France in the 1904 **Entente Cordiale**, and with Russia in the 1907 **Anglo-Russian Convention**. Together, Britain, France, and Russia formed the **Triple Entente**. Europe was now split into two hostile armed camps. Like a chain of dynamite, a quarrel between any two powers threatened to drag all six into war.

[4.3] THE "BALKAN POWDER KEG", OTTOMAN DECLINE & PAN-SLAVISM (1900–1908)

For centuries, the **Ottoman Empire** ruled the Balkan peninsula. By 1900, Ottoman power was fading rapidly, earning the nickname the "Sick Man of Europe." As Turkish rule collapsed, new independent nations—Greece, Bulgaria, Romania, and **Serbia**—broke away. This unstable power vacuum became known as the **"Balkan Powder Keg."**

Two rival empires competed for influence in the Balkans. Russia supported fellow Slavs and Orthodox Christians under the banner of **Pan-Slavism**, seeking warm-water sea routes to the Mediterranean. In contrast, Austria-Hungary feared that Slavic nationalism would tear its empire apart. Independent Serbia wanted to unite all South Slavs into a "Greater Serbia," making it Austria's fiercest rival.

[4.4] THE 1908 BOSNIAN ANNEXATION CRISIS & RUSSIAN HUMILIATION (OCTOBER 1908)

In October 1908, the powder keg nearly exploded. Taking advantage of chaos in the Ottoman Empire, Austria-Hungary **annexed the provinces of Bosnia and Herzegovina**. This annexation outraged Serbia, which considered Bosnia its rightful territory. Serbian crowds protested in Belgrade, demanding war.

Russia supported Serbia and prepared its army. However, German Chancellor Bernhard von Bülow intervened. In March 1909, Germany delivered an ultimatum: Russia must accept the annexation, or face war with Germany and Austria. Still recovering from its 1905 defeat by Japan, Russia could not fight. Tsar Nicholas II backed down and forced Serbia to accept Austrian rule. The humiliation was painful: Russia began rapid military rearmament and resolved never to surrender in the Balkans again.

[4.5] THE 1912–1913 BALKAN WARS & THE PRE-EMPTIVE WAR URGE (1912–1913)

In October 1912, the **First Balkan War** broke out. Serbia, Greece, Bulgaria, and Montenegro (the Balkan League) attacked the Ottoman Empire, expelling Turkish forces from Europe within six weeks. In 1913, the allies turned on each other in the **Second Balkan War**, where Serbia defeated Bulgaria.

These wars transformed Serbia into a formidable regional power. Serbia expanded its territory by eighty percent, and its population jumped from three to 4.5 million. Armed with modern French artillery, Serbian nationalists intensified secret agitation inside Austria-Hungary. In Vienna, Austrian General **Franz Conrad von Hötzendorf** demanded a **pre-emptive war** to crush Serbia before it grew even stronger: Conrad urged war over twenty times in 1913 alone. Europe stood on the edge of catastrophe.

ENQUIRY 05

PILLAR 1 • CORE NARRATIVE

The July Crisis: Sarajevo to the Outbreak of War (June–August 1914)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite thirty-seven days of diplomatic madness and world war?

[5.1] THE ASSASSINATION OF FRANZ FERDINAND IN SARAJEVO (28 JUNE 1914)

On Sunday, 28 June 1914, **Archduke Franz Ferdinand**, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, visited **Sarajevo** with his wife Sophie. The date was *Vidovdan* (St Vitus Day), a sacred Serbian national holiday. Six young assassins from **Young Bosnia** waited along the Appel Quay. They were armed with pistols and bombs supplied by the Serbian secret society, the **Black Hand**, led by Colonel Dragutin Dimitrijević ("Apis").

The first attack failed when a bomb bounced off the car, injuring bystanders. After a City Hall reception, Franz Ferdinand decided to visit the wounded in hospital. However, his driver took a wrong turn onto Franz Josef Street outside **Schiller's Delicatessen** near the **Latin Bridge**. When ordered to reverse, the car stalled. Standing nearby was nineteen-year-old student **Gavrilo Princip**. Princip stepped forward and fired two shots at close range, killing Sophie and Franz Ferdinand within minutes.

[5.2] THE "BLANK CHEQUE" & THE ESCALATION OF THE CRISIS (5 JULY 1914)

The assassination caused shock and outrage across Europe. Austrian leaders decided to use the murders as an excuse to destroy the Serbian threat forever. However, attacking Serbia risked a war with Russia. On 5 July 1914, Austrian envoy Count Alexander Hoyos traveled to Berlin to secure German support.

Kaiser Wilhelm II and Chancellor Theobald von Bethmann-Hollweg made a fateful decision. They issued the famous **"Blank Cheque" (Blankovollmacht)**, promising unconditional German military backing to Austria-Hungary. Germany urged Vienna to strike quickly while international sympathy was high. German leaders gambled that Russia was not ready to fight and that Britain would remain neutral. Strengthened by German promises, Austrian leaders prepared for war.

[5.3] THE TEN-POINT ULTIMATUM & DECLARATION OF WAR ON SERBIA (23–28 JULY 1914)

On 23 July 1914, Austria-Hungary sent a harsh **Ten-Point Ultimatum** to Serbia, demanding an answer within forty-eight hours. The terms were deliberately designed to be impossible to accept. Austria demanded that Serbia ban anti-Austrian newspapers, dismiss hostile officers, and allow Austro-Hungarian police onto Serbian soil.

Allowing foreign police on sovereign soil would destroy Serbian independence. However, advised by Russia to show restraint, Serbia accepted eight demands and offered international arbitration for the other two. British Foreign Secretary Sir Edward Grey praised Serbia's peaceful reply. Nevertheless, Austria-Hungary was determined to fight. On **28 July 1914**, Austria declared war on Serbia. That night, Austrian gunboats shelled Belgrade from the Danube River. The July Crisis had turned into war.

[5.4] RAILWAY MOBILISATION SCHEDULES & THE DOMINO EFFECT (29–31 JULY 1914)

The shelling of Belgrade set off the alliance system like dominoes. Russian commanders warned Tsar Nicholas II that if Russia failed to act, Austria would conquer the Balkans. Because Russia was vast with few railways, its army took six weeks to assemble. Delaying mobilization would leave Russia defenseless. On **30 July 1914**, the Tsar ordered **general mobilization**.

Russian mobilization triggered rigid military plans across Europe, a process historian A.J.P. Taylor called **"War by Timetable."** In 1914, mobilization was treated as an act of war involving millions of troops and inflexible train schedules. German Chief of Staff **Helmuth von Moltke the Younger** warned that war could no longer be stopped. Germany ordered Russia to halt mobilization, and demanded that France promise neutrality. Both refused. On 1 August, Germany declared war on Russia; on 3 August, Germany declared war on France.

[5.5] THE SCHLIEFFEN PLAN, BELGIAN NEUTRALITY & BRITISH ENTRY (1–4 AUGUST 1914)

Germany's strategy was dictated by the **Schlieffen Plan**, designed by Count Alfred von Schlieffen to prevent a two-front war. The plan assumed Russia would take six weeks to mobilize. During those six weeks, Germany would send ninety percent of its army through neutral **Belgium** to encircle Paris and knock France out in forty-two days, before turning east to fight Russia.

On 2 August, Germany demanded free passage through Belgium. King Albert refused, declaring: *"Belgium is a nation, not a road."* On **3 August 1914**, German armies invaded Belgium. This invasion brought Great Britain into the war. Britain had promised to protect Belgian neutrality in the **1839 Treaty of London**, and could not allow a hostile power to control Channel ports. When Germany dismissed the treaty as a *"scrap of paper,"* Britain declared war at 11:00 PM on **4 August 1914**. Watching London's street lamps, Sir Edward Grey remarked: *"The lamps are going out all over Europe; we shall not see them lit again in our lifetime."*

BACK COVER • RETRIEVAL ENGINE

MASTER KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL QUIZ

Standard Recall Protocol: 25 core retrieval questions testing factual mastery across all five enquiries. Use for low-stakes weekly partner testing, silent memory flash-checks, or end-of-unit homework retrieval. *(Answers verified in textbook narrative; zero answers printed.)*

ENQUIRY 1: GERMAN UNIFICATION & BISMARCK

Page 3 • Ref [1.1]–[1.6]

1. How many independent German-speaking states existed in Central Europe before 1871?
2. What economic customs union established by Prussia in 1834 bound German states together?
3. What famous phrase did Otto von Bismarck use to declare how German unification would be decided?
4. Which two border provinces did defeated France cede to Germany in the 1871 Treaty of Frankfurt?
5. What was the name of the secret 1887 treaty negotiated by Bismarck to prevent a two-front war with Russia?

ENQUIRY 2: IMPERIAL RIVALRY & MOROCCO

Page 4 • Ref [2.1]–[2.5]

6. What diplomatic conference did Bismarck host in 1884–1885 to regulate the Scramble for Africa?
7. Which aggressive foreign policy did Kaiser Wilhelm II adopt after dismissing Bismarck in 1890?
8. At which Moroccan port did Kaiser Wilhelm II land in March 1905 to provoke the French Republic?
9. Which 1906 international conference rejected German demands and upheld French control in Morocco?
10. What was the name of the German naval gunboat sent to Agadir during the Second Moroccan Crisis in 1911?

ENQUIRY 3: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT

Page 5 • Ref [3.1]–[3.5]

11. What British naval standard required the Royal Navy to be larger than the next two largest navies combined?
12. Which German Naval Minister designed the "Risk Theory" to challenge British dominance in the North Sea?
13. In what year was the revolutionary all-big-gun British battleship HMS Dreadnought launched?
14. Which British First Sea Lord championed steam-turbine propulsion and the development of Dreadnought?
15. What popular British public slogan was coined in 1909 demanding eight new battleships from Parliament?

ENQUIRY 4: ALLIANCE SYSTEMS & THE BALKANS

Page 6 • Ref [4.1]–[4.5]

16. Which three major Central European powers made up the defensive Triple Alliance by 1882?
17. What term described Britain's traditional nineteenth-century policy of avoiding continental military pacts?
18. Which three European nations completed the counter-balancing Triple Entente by 1907?
19. Which Balkan province was formally annexed by Austria-Hungary in October 1908, enraging Serbia?
20. Why was the Balkan region commonly described as the "Powder Keg of Europe" in the decade before 1914?

ENQUIRY 5: THE JULY CRISIS & SARAJEVO

Page 7 • Ref [5.1]–[5.5]

21. On what exact date were Archduke Franz Ferdinand and his wife Sophie assassinated in Sarajevo?
22. Which nineteen-year-old Bosnian Serb radical fired the fatal shots on the Latin Bridge?
23. What secret Serbian military nationalist organisation supplied the weapons for the assassination?
24. What informal name was given to Germany's unconditional pledge of military support to Austria on 5 July 1914?
25. The invasion of which neutral nation by the German army compelled Great Britain to declare war on 4 August 1914?